with Moin Khan in his room. A fellow Karachiite, he was really happy for me and told me what a big deal it was that I had managed to pull off a century in 37 balls. He broke down my performance as a teammate, a spectator, even a coach. But I still didn't realize the gravity of what I had just done. It was all happening too fast. I was just happy to have the opportunity of playing with my favourite cricketers – and Pakistan's finest – against the world champions that year.

It was only after the tour, when we returned to Pakistan, that I was forced to change my mind. There were thousands of supporters at Karachi's Jinnah International Airport who came to see me, probably to catch a glimpse of a random Pathan kid from Gulshan who had created a world record out of nowhere. The song and dance at the airport, the flowers they threw at me, the way they carried me on their shoulders and hugged and kissed me – it was their warmth, pride and love that made me realize what I had done.

That's when it hit me. That's when it all started to make sense. I had indeed done something serious, something big, even historic. Not the century itself. Not the praise in the dressing room. Not the late-night chat with Moin.

It was getting off that flight that changed everything – my game, my life, my family's future. More than anything, it changed my own perception of myself.

But the future wasn't as rosy as that welcome at Karachi Airport made me think it would be.